CHAPTER 1

The Clock That Was Never There

"Then God said, 'I give you every seed-bearing plant on the face of the whole earth and every tree that has fruit with seed in it. They will be yours for food.'"

— Genesis 1:29 (NIV)

Are You Hungry, or Is It Just Time?

Let me ask you something before we start.

Are you hungry right now? Or is it just that time?

When noon comes around, most of us start thinking about lunch. The stomach starts talking. Some of us get a little short with people until we eat. And we tell ourselves, "I'm hungry. My body needs food."

Maybe it does.

But what if your body isn't asking for food at all? What if it has just been trained to expect it at noon?

That's the question this whole chapter is built on. And it's a bigger question than it sounds. It cost me years of my health before I asked it. It cost my wife hers too. I'll tell you what happened when we finally did.

In the Introduction, I talked about smoke rising above the trees. Nobody spends the afternoon trying to sweep the smoke away. Smoke is only the sign that something else is burning.

Weight that won't stay off. Blood sugar creeping up. Blood pressure pills. Feeling tired and heavy after every meal. That's the smoke. In this chapter, we start looking for the fire. And the first place I found it surprised me. It wasn't only in what we eat. It was in when.

The Thing Everybody Thinks Is Solid

If you've never built a fence, here is all you need to know. The post holds everything up. If the post is rotten down in the ground, you can tighten every wire and straighten every board, and it still falls over. The problem was never what you were looking at. It was what everything was standing on.

The hard part is that a rotten post doesn't always look rotten. You grab it, give it a good shake, and it doesn't move. You walk away satisfied. The rot is down where you can't see it.

Some of the weakest things in our lives look the strongest. They feel normal. Nobody questions them. We've lived with them so long we can't picture life without them.

I believe one of those is the clock we eat by.

Breakfast. Lunch. Dinner. Three meals a day, and snacks in between.

Your parents probably ate that way. Your school ran on it. Your job runs on it. Your body has gotten so used to it that when a meal comes late, you feel it. Hungry at noon, not always

because your body needs fuel, but because the clock says it's time.

So who decided that?

Where the Clock Came From

Most of us assume people have always eaten three meals a day. For most of history, they didn't.

People ate when there was food. They ate when the work was done. They ate when the body called. The fisherman ate when the catch came in. The farmer ate when the field was worked. Some days there was plenty. Some days there was little. Not everything was eaten every day, and nobody thought that was strange.

Our Kūpuna here in Hawai'i lived by the fishing, the planting and the gathering. Their eating followed their work and what the ʻĀina and the ocean gave them. Not a clock on the wall.

Even in Europe, three meals a day is newer than most people think. Until about 1800, most English people ate two meals a day, with the big meal, called dinner, around midday. Researchers in Australia point to evidence that Aboriginal peoples tended toward one main meal a day. Among the Iroquois nations of North America, the American scholar Lewis Henry Morgan, who spent years among the Seneca, recorded in 1881 their custom "of having but one prepared meal each day." When food was scarce, Native peoples in America fasted. And when the European settlers saw it, they were shocked. One

historian who studied American mealtimes, Abigail Carroll, writes that the Europeans took this as "evidence that natives were uncivilized."

Think about that. The way the Kūpuna of many peoples ate, by the body, by the season, by the work, was looked down on as uncivilized. And the clock was held up as the civilized way.

The fixed three-meal day, the way most of us know it, grew up mostly with factories and shift work. Breakfast before the whistle. Lunch on the break. Dinner after the shift. Schools and offices followed the same pattern. Little by little, the clock started deciding when people ate. Not the body.

Then the food business learned how to sell into that schedule. Breakfast foods. Lunch specials. Snacks for between meals. Food that comes in a box or a bag and keeps for months on a shelf. Most of the people involved weren't trying to hurt anyone. But the schedule kept getting more crowded, the food kept getting more processed, and very little of it was decided by what our bodies actually needed.

I'm not saying breakfast is bad or lunch is wrong. I'm saying the clock, and the food that came with it, came into our lives for reasons that had very little to do with your health. And we've been leaning on both ever since.

What God Said, and What He Left Out

When I went looking for what was there before the clock, I went back to the beginning. I opened Genesis.

In Genesis 1:29, God gives the plants and the fruit trees to the man and the woman and says, "They will be yours for food." Then in Genesis 2:16, He tells the man, "You are free to eat from any tree in the garden."

Read those first chapters slowly and you'll notice something. God talks about what to eat. He never says when.

There is no breakfast in the garden. No lunch hour. No three times a day. Just food as it grows, and a body that knew when it was hungry and when it had enough. I don't believe that silence is an accident. I believe it's part of the design.

Later, when God fed His people in the wilderness, He gave them manna and told them to gather it "every man according to his eating" (Exodus 16:16, KJV). Each person gathered what they needed. Not a set portion. Not a schedule. Their own need. You'll find more on that Hebrew word on the Word Study page at the end of this chapter.

God provides. The body knows its need. And enough is enough.

What the Animals Already Know

I spent thirty years working cattle and horses on Moloka‘i, Maui, the Big Island and in Colorado. I don't bring it up because you need to know anything about ranching. I bring it up because animals don't lie about hunger.

I'll tell you more of what the animals taught me in the next chapter. For now, here's one picture almost everybody knows.

If you've ever fed a dog at five o'clock every day, you know. By a quarter to five, that dog is at the door. Pacing. Whining. Watching you. Is the dog starving? No. We put it on a clock, and now the clock is running the dog.

Now let's be honest about ourselves.

How many of us are anxious around food? We feel starving at mealtime when we weren't really hungry an hour ago. We eat past full because we know it will be hours before we're "supposed" to eat again. We eat because it's there. We eat because everybody else is eating. We eat because the clock says so.

And then we feel bad about it. So we tell ourselves, "I don't have enough discipline."

Maybe. But maybe discipline isn't the main problem. Maybe you've been trying hard while standing on something that was never part of the design. New diet. New plan. New rules. But if all of it is still tied to the same clock and the same kind of food, it's like putting brand new wire on a rotten post. It looks better for a while. Then it leans again.

What Happened to Us

I didn't learn this from a book. I learned it the hard way.

For years I did what everybody does. Three meals a day. Eating because it was time. Trying diets and watching them fail. Along the way I picked up high blood pressure, and my blood tests showed I was prediabetic. My waist was 42 inches.

Then I started doing something very simple. I stopped eating by the clock. I ate only when I was truly hungry, and I stopped when I'd had enough. I added a little olive oil every day, which I'll tell you about in a moment. No gym. No special food. No counting.

Over the months that followed, 54 pounds came off, and my waist went from 42 inches to 34. And this is the part that matters most to me: my high blood pressure went away, and so did my prediabetes. We have the blood test results to show it.

My wife started eating the same way. She had hyperthyroidism and diabetes. Today her blood work shows both are gone.

I'm not telling you this to promise that the same thing will happen to you. Every body is different, and I'm not your doctor. I'm telling you because it happened to us, here on Molokaʻi, eating this way. And because when I went looking for why, I found that it had happened to whole peoples before us, in both directions.

What the Research Shows

Here is something I have studied for years. Wherever native peoples kept eating their own native foods, type 2 diabetes was rare or unknown. Wherever processed food from America and Europe came in and replaced those foods, diabetes followed. Often within a generation or two.

Diabetes itself isn't new. Physicians in India described it about 2,500 years ago. They called it madhumeha, "honey urine," because ants came to the urine. Doctors in ancient China and Greece described it too. But they saw it rarely. Galen, one of the

most famous doctors of the ancient world, said he saw it only twice in his whole life. And the Indian physicians tied the overweight kind to rich food, sweets and an idle life. That was the diet of the wealthy, not the daily food of the farmer and the fisherman. What is new is how common it has become.

Look at the Pima people, who live on both sides of the border between Arizona and Mexico. Same ancestry. Same genes. In Arizona, living the modern American way, 38 percent of them have type 2 diabetes. In the mountains of Mexico, where they still farm and work the old way, it's 6.9 percent. More than five times higher, with the same genes. The difference is the way of life.

Look at our cousins across the Pacific. Nauru, Samoa, Kiribati, the Marshall Islands and Tonga now have some of the highest diabetes rates on earth, around one in four adults in several of them. Their grandparents lived on fish, root crops, fruit and coconut, much like our Kūpuna did. Then imported, processed food took over their tables. On Nauru, mining ruined most of the land for gardening, and the people came to depend on food shipped in from Australia and New Zealand. Today about 31 percent of adults there have diabetes.

Look at China. In 1980, about 1 percent of adults had diabetes. By 2013, it was about 11 percent. The researchers who studied it pointed to more refined grains, more processed meat and sugary drinks, and much less physical work. Their words were "the rapid Westernization of the Chinese diet."

And look at what happens when people go back.

In 1984, ten Aboriginal Australians with type 2 diabetes went back to live off their own land the traditional way. For just seven weeks. Their blood sugar, insulin and blood fats improved so much that the researcher said the main problems of their diabetes were "greatly improved or fully normalized."

Closer to home, in 1991, the Waiʻanae Diet study fed nineteen Native Hawaiians our traditional foods, Kalo, Poi, ʻUala, ʻUlu, greens and fish, for three weeks. They could eat as much as they wanted. No counting. On average they lost about 17 pounds, and their cholesterol and blood sugar went down. Years later, most of them had kept the weight off.

Three weeks. Seven weeks. That's how fast the body starts coming home when we give it what it was made for.

I want to be honest about two things, so nobody can knock this down. First, type 1 diabetes is a different disease. It's an autoimmune condition found in every people, and food does not cause it. Everything I'm describing here is about type 2. Second, these studies looked at the whole way of life: the food, the work and the moving. None of them measured eating less often by itself. That part comes from what the Kūpuna practiced, from what my wife and I have lived, and from what I've watched happen in the people around me.

What's Really Underneath

So what was there before the clock?

Something already built into your body. Hunger is real. It's a good signal, and it's there for a reason. Full is real too. Your body knows when it has had enough. The clock didn't create

either one. It just taught us to stop listening to them.

Science has been looking at this for a while now. Researchers who study the body's daily rhythms have found that the body does important work in the hours when it isn't busy digesting. In 2016, the Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine went to Yoshinori Ohsumi for his work on autophagy, the way our cells break down and recycle their own worn-out parts. Studies, many of them in cells and animals, show that going longer without food is one of the things that turns that process up. There's still a lot being learned about what that means for people, and I won't promise more than the research does.

But I'll tell you what I believe. I didn't find this in a lab. I found it in creation, in Scripture, in the lives of our Kūpuna and in my own blood work. The research is just catching up to what was built in from the start.

The design is simple. Eat when you're truly hungry. Stop when you've had enough. Eat real food, the way it grows. Trust the way you were made.

That isn't a diet. It isn't a new schedule or another set of rules. It's coming back to what was there in the first place.

The Olive Oil

Along with eating only when I'm hungry, there's one thing I added every day: extra virgin olive oil.

Here's what I do.

- Two teaspoons a day, until the weight you want to lose has come off.

- You can take it with food, or even in your coffee. I like to take it plain, right off the spoon. That way I get the most of the polyphenols.

Polyphenols are natural compounds in olives that protect the oil, and research shows they help protect us too. They're found in extra virgin olive oil. Refined or "light" olive oil has had most of them taken out, so read the label.

The best-known research on olive oil comes from Spain. It's called PREDIMED. In one part of that study, about 3,500 people aged 55 to 80 who didn't have diabetes ate a Mediterranean-style diet with extra virgin olive oil added. Their risk of getting diabetes was about 40 percent lower than in the comparison group. In Europe, the food safety authority has approved the claim that olive oil polyphenols help protect blood fats from damage, for olive oil rich in those polyphenols.

The olive tree is all through the Bible, from the dove that brought Noah an olive leaf to the oil that anointed kings. I find it fitting that God gave us a food that does this.

> *A word of care: if you have diabetes, high blood pressure, a thyroid condition, take medication, are pregnant or nursing, or are under a doctor's care, talk with your doctor before you change how or when you eat. If you take medicine for blood sugar or blood pressure, your doctor may need to adjust it as your numbers improve. Learning to listen to your body includes listening to the people who are helping you take care of it.*

Coming Back to the Kūpuna Table

You don't have to give up everything to start coming home. You can start with what our Kūpuna ate, much of it still grown on our islands and sold in our stores.

- Kalo, and Poi made from it. The heart of the Hawaiian table for generations.
- ʻUala, sweet potato. Filling, easy to grow, and good in any meal.
- ʻUlu, breadfruit. One tree can feed a family through its season.
- Lūʻau, the young Kalo leaves, cooked well. Real greens from the same plant.
- Niu, coconut. Its meat, its milk and its water.
- Iʻa, fish from the ocean and the fishpond.
- Limu, seaweed from the shoreline.
- Fruit in its season: Maiʻa (banana), and whatever the ʻĀina is giving that month.

Notice what's missing. Nothing on that list comes in a box. Nothing has a list of ingredients you can't pronounce. Nothing was made to sit on a shelf for a year. And none of it was eaten on a clock, or all of it every single day. The Kūpuna ate what the season gave, when the work was done and the body called.

If you're not in Hawaiʻi, the lesson is the same. Look back at what your own grandparents' grandparents ate before the boxes and bags came. Start there.

One simple way to begin: the next time you're truly hungry, reach for one food from this list instead of something from a package. Notice how long it keeps you satisfied.

Try This

Don't change everything. Just for the next seven days, before you eat, stop and ask yourself one question:

"Am I hungry, or is it just the time?"

That's all. You don't have to skip anything. You don't have to prove anything. Just notice.

- Notice when your body is really asking, and when it's only the clock.
- Notice how hungry you actually are before each meal, and how full you are after.
- Notice how you feel when you stop at enough instead of stuffed.
- Use the 7-Day Journal at the end of this chapter to write down what you notice.

Questions to Ask Yourself

This is the Rotten Fencepost way of looking at a problem. Don't stop at the first answer that sounds right. Ask what it's standing on.

1. What can I actually see about the way I eat? What do I know as fact?

2. What have I always assumed about when I'm supposed to eat? Where did I learn that?
3. When I say "I'm hungry," how often is it my body, and how often is it the clock, the people around me, or how I feel?
4. What did my great-grandparents eat? How much of what I eat now did they never see?
5. What if the problem isn't my discipline at all, but what my eating has been standing on?

Coming Home

Sometimes the thing that feels the most normal is the thing we've never checked. And sometimes it isn't something we chose. It was handed to us. Scheduled into our school day. Built into our work day. Sold to us in a box. Repeated until it felt like the way things have always been.

But it isn't the way things have always been. The way things have always been is the way you were made.

In the chapters ahead, we'll go deeper into the foods themselves, into rest and work, into what our Kūpuna knew, and into the things that have cost our families so much. But this had to come first. Without it, everything else is just one more rule.

Your body already knows how to be well.

It has always known.

We just have to stop telling it something different.

Word Study: The Words for Food

In this book, when we look at a word from Scripture, we look at it in the original Tanakh Hebrew or Koine Greek, and we let the verse it's in tell us what it means. The same word can mean different things in different places.

אָכְלָה

okhlah (ok-LAH)

> Food, that which is eaten. From the root אכל (akal), to eat. This is the word in Genesis 1:29: "They will be yours for food." In this verse it tells us what God gave. It says nothing about a time.

אֹכֶל

okel (OH-kel)

> Food, eating. A sister word from the same root. In Ruth 2:14 it is part of the phrase "at mealtime," a set time to eat. But in Exodus 16:16 and 16:18, it describes each person's own need.

In the wilderness, God told His people to gather the manna "every man according to his eating" (Exodus 16:16, KJV). The Hebrew is literally "according to his okel." When they measured it, "he that gathered much had nothing over, and he that gathered little had no lack; they gathered every man according to his eating" (Exodus 16:18, KJV). The NIV puts it this way: "Everyone had gathered just as much as they needed."

Same word, two verses, two meanings. In Ruth, it is a mealtime. In the wilderness, God Himself measured the food by each person's need.

Think About It

1. In Genesis, God said what to eat but never when. What does that silence say to you?
2. When God fed His people in the wilderness, He measured by need, not by schedule. What would it look like to eat "according to your eating"?

7-Day Journal

Each day, before you eat, ask: "Am I hungry, or is it just the time?" Then write a line or two below. There are no wrong answers. You're just learning to listen.

Day 1

Day 2

Day 3

Day 4

Day 5

Day 6

Day 7

After Seven Days

What surprised you most? What will you keep doing?

Chapter One at a Glance

> **The question:** Am I hungry, or is it just the time?

> **The rotten post:** The three-meal clock, and the processed food that came with it. It looks solid because everybody leans on it.

> **What God said:** He told us what to eat, never when (Genesis 1:29). In the wilderness, He fed His people "every man according to his eating" (Exodus 16:16).

> **What the research shows:** Where native peoples kept their native foods, type 2 diabetes was rare. Where processed food came in, it followed. When people went back, it turned around in weeks.

> **What happened to us:** 54 pounds gone, waist from 42 to 34, high blood pressure and prediabetes gone. My wife's hyperthyroidism and diabetes gone.

> **The design:** Eat when you're truly hungry. Stop when you've had enough. Eat real food, the way it grows. Add a little extra virgin olive oil each day.

> **This week:** Ask the one question before every meal, and write in your journal.

> **Remember:** Talk with your doctor first if you have a health condition or take medication.

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